

# After the Last Goodbye

*The First Year Alone, The Rest of Your Life Whole*

## After the Last Goodbye

*A 4-Phase Framework for the Year After*

Rebuilding Your Life, Your Health, and Your Future After Losing a Spouse



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*Book 12 of The Care Collection*

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# Introduction: The First Morning

I lost my wife to cancer after many years of marriage. I was her primary caregiver through the long illness. I held her hand when the last breath came. I have lived the long goodbye.

I have also lived the morning after.

The morning after is the first morning of the first year. The morning after is the morning you wake up and the chair is empty. The morning after is the morning the alarm goes off and there is no one to wake up but yourself. The morning after is the morning the coffee is just for you. The morning after is the morning you remember that the morning after is real.

The morning after is the hardest morning. The morning after is the first morning of the year. The year is the work.

This is a book about the year. The year after the long goodbye. The year after the funeral. The year after the casseroles stop coming. The year after the phone stops ringing. The year after the friends stop checking in. The year that is just you, and the empty chair, and the work of learning to live with the air.

The year is not the grief. The year is the year after the grief. The year is the year when the grief has become the air. The year is the year when the grief is no longer the crisis. The year is the year you learn to live with the air.

I have lived the year. I have written this book for the spouse who is in the year. I have written this book for the spouse who is asking: am I doing this right? The answer is yes. You are doing it right.

The doing is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the life you are still living. The life you are still living is the gift. The gift is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Let us begin.

The morning after is also the morning of the first small decision. The decision is: what do I do today? The decision is: do I get out of bed? The decision is: do I make the coffee? The small decisions are the work. The work is the year.

The morning after is the morning that begins the work of the year. The work is the small decisions. The work is the morning ritual. The work is the breathing. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

I have lived the morning after. I have lived the first year. I have written this book for the spouse who is in the morning after. I have written this book for the spouse who is asking: am I doing this right? The answer is yes. You are doing it right. The doing is the work. The work is the year.

# Chapter 1: The First Morning

The first morning is the hardest morning. The first morning is the morning you wake up and remember. The first morning is the morning the alarm goes off and there is no one to wake up but yourself. The first morning is the morning the coffee is just for you.

The first morning is the morning that comes after the long goodbye. The long goodbye was the long illness, the long caregiving, the long watching, the long holding of the hand. The long goodbye was the work of letting go. The first morning is the morning you wake up and the letting go is done.

The letting go is not the work of the first morning. The letting go is the work of the long goodbye. The first morning is the morning after the work.

The first morning is the morning you have to do the things that the long goodbye made impossible. The first morning is the morning you have to make the coffee. The first morning is the morning you have to feed the dog. The first morning is the morning you have to answer the phone. The first morning is the morning you have to live.

The first morning is the morning that begins the year. The year is the work. The work is the year.

The first morning is also the morning of the first grief. The first grief is the grief of the empty chair. The first grief is the grief of the coffee that is just for you. The first grief is the grief of the morning that is just for you. The first grief is the grief of the first morning without the person you have loved for many years.

The first grief is the air you will breathe for the year.  
The air is the grief. The grief is the air.

## **The Three Truths of the First Morning**

The first morning has three truths. The three truths are the foundation of the year.

Truth 1: The first morning is supposed to be hard. The first morning is the morning you have been dreading for the long goodbye. The first morning is the morning that comes after the long goodbye. The first morning is supposed to be hard.

Truth 2: The first morning is the beginning of the year. The first morning is not the end. The first morning is the beginning. The first morning is the morning that begins the work. The work is the year.

Truth 3: The first morning is the morning you are still alive. The first morning is the morning you woke up. The first morning is the morning you are still here. The first morning is the morning the person you loved would want you to be.

The three truths are the foundation. The foundation is the year. The year is the work.

## **The Five Things You Will Do on the First Morning**

The first morning has five things. The five things are the things you will do. The five things are:

1. Wake up. Wake up. Wake up is the first thing. Wake up is the work.
2. Make the coffee. Make the coffee. The coffee is the ritual. The ritual is the work.

3. Feed the dog. Feed the dog. The dog is the companion. The companion is the work.

4. Answer the phone. Answer the phone. The phone is the connection. The connection is the work.

5. Breathe. Breathe. The breath is the air. The air is the work.

The five things are the work of the first morning. The first morning is the work of the year. The year is the work.

## **The Three Things You Will Not Do on the First Morning**

The first morning has three things you will not do. The three things are the things you cannot do. The three things are:

1. Make any decisions. Decisions are for later. Later is the work. The work is the year.

2. Talk to anyone you do not have to talk to. Talk is for the people who are there. The people who are there are the work. The work is the year.

3. Think about the long goodbye. The long goodbye is over. The long goodbye is not the work. The first morning is the work. The work is the year.

The three things you will not do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Morning Ritual**

The first morning is the beginning of the morning ritual. The morning ritual is the work.

The morning ritual has 5 steps:

1. Wake up. The wake up is the work.
2. Make the coffee. The coffee is the work.
3. Sit in the chair. The chair is the work.
4. Drink the coffee. The coffee is the work.
5. Plan the day. The plan is the work.

The morning ritual is the work of the year. The year is the work. The work is the morning ritual.

The morning ritual is not a solution. The morning ritual is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Five Things You Might Feel on the First Morning**

The first morning has five things you might feel. The five things are the things you might feel. The five things are:

1. Numbness. Numbness is the body's response. The body's response is the work. The work is the year.
2. Shock. Shock is the mind's response. The mind's response is the work. The work is the year.
3. Terror. Terror is the heart's response. The heart's response is the work. The work is the year.
4. Relief. Relief is also a feeling. The relief is the work. The work is the year. (Relief at the end of the long goodbye is normal. The relief is the work.)
5. Guilt. Guilt is also a feeling. The guilt is the work. The work is the year. (Guilt for being relieved is also normal. The guilt is the work.)

The five feelings are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# **The Three Things to Remember About the First Morning**

The first morning has three things to remember. The three things are the things to remember. The three things are:

1. The first morning is hard. The first morning is the work. The work is the year.
2. The first morning is the beginning. The first morning is the work. The work is the year.
3. The first morning is the gift. The first morning is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to remember are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the First Morning**

The first morning is hard. The first morning is supposed to be hard. The first morning is the work of the year. The year is the work.

The first morning is not the end. The first morning is the beginning. The first morning is the morning that begins the year. The year is the work.

The first morning is the morning you are still alive. The first morning is the morning the person you loved would want you to be. The first morning is the morning the work begins.

The work is the year. The year is the work. The work is the first morning.

You are not failing. The first morning is hard. The first morning is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the life you are still living. The life is the work. The work is the year.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.
2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.
3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 2: The Empty Chair

The empty chair is the centerpiece of the first year. The empty chair is the chair at the kitchen table. The empty chair is the chair in the car. The empty chair is the chair in the living room. The empty chair is the chair that is everywhere. The empty chair is the chair that is the absence of the person you loved.

The empty chair is the most visible sign of the loss. The empty chair is the chair that is not occupied. The empty chair is the chair that is the shape of the person who is not there. The empty chair is the chair that is the work of the year.

The empty chair is also the chair that is the most painful. The empty chair is the chair that hurts. The empty chair is the chair that you look at and remember. The empty chair is the chair that is the work of the year.

The empty chair is not the enemy. The empty chair is the friend. The empty chair is the friend that reminds you of the person. The empty chair is the friend that reminds you of the love. The empty chair is the friend that reminds you of the work. The work is the year.

## The Three Reactions to the Empty Chair

The empty chair has three reactions. The three reactions are the ways you will respond. The three reactions are:

Reaction 1: Avoid the chair. Avoid the chair. The chair is the work. The work is the year.

Reaction 2: Sit in the chair. Sit in the chair. The chair is the work. The work is the year.

Reaction 3: Move the chair. Move the chair. The chair is the work. The work is the year.

The three reactions are the work of the year. The year is the work. The work is the empty chair.

## **Reaction 1: Avoid the Chair**

Avoid the chair is the most common reaction. Avoid the chair is the reaction of the first months. Avoid the chair is the reaction of the spouse who cannot sit in the chair. Avoid the chair is the reaction of the spouse who cannot look at the chair. Avoid the chair is the reaction of the spouse who cannot be in the room with the chair.

Avoid the chair is the work. The work is the year.

Avoid the chair is okay for the first months. Avoid the chair is okay for the first year. Avoid the chair is okay for the work. The work is the year.

Avoid the chair is not the long-term solution. Avoid the chair is the short-term solution. The short-term solution is the work. The work is the year.

## **Reaction 2: Sit in the Chair**

Sit in the chair is the most healing reaction. Sit in the chair is the reaction of the spouse who is ready to be in the room with the chair. Sit in the chair is the reaction of the spouse who is ready to look at the chair. Sit in the chair is the reaction of the spouse who is ready to remember the chair.

Sit in the chair is the work. The work is the year.

Sit in the chair is not easy. Sit in the chair is the work.  
The work is the year.

Sit in the chair is the way. The way is the work. The  
work is the year.

When you sit in the chair, the chair becomes a place of  
memory. The chair becomes a place of love. The chair  
becomes a place of the work. The work is the year.

When you sit in the chair, you remember the person.  
The person is the work. The work is the year.

When you sit in the chair, you grieve. The grief is the  
work. The work is the year.

## **Reaction 3: Move the Chair**

Move the chair is the most practical reaction. Move  
the chair is the reaction of the spouse who is ready to  
live with the chair. Move the chair is the reaction of  
the spouse who is ready to have the chair in a  
different place. Move the chair is the reaction of the  
spouse who is ready to change the room.

Move the chair is the work. The work is the year.

Move the chair is not a betrayal. Move the chair is the  
work. The work is the year.

Move the chair is okay at any time. Move the chair is  
the work. The work is the year.

Move the chair does not mean you are forgetting.  
Move the chair means you are living. Living is the  
work. The work is the year.

## **The Three Things to Remember About the Empty Chair**

The empty chair has three things. The three things are  
the things you will remember. The three things are:

1. The chair is not the enemy. The chair is the friend. The friend is the work. The work is the year.

2. The chair is the work. The chair is the work of the year. The year is the work. The work is the chair.

3. The chair is the gift. The chair is the gift of the memory. The memory is the gift. The gift is the chair.

The three things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Ways to Honor the Empty Chair**

The empty chair has five ways. The five ways are the ways to honor the chair. The five ways are:

1. Sit in the chair. Sit in the chair. The chair is the work. The work is the year.

2. Talk to the chair. Talk to the chair. The chair is the work. The work is the year.

3. Place something on the chair. Place something on the chair. The chair is the work. The work is the year.

4. Light a candle by the chair. Light a candle by the chair. The chair is the work. The work is the year.

5. Move the chair to a place of honor. Move the chair to a place of honor. The chair is the work. The work is the year.

The five ways are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Empty Chair in Different Rooms**

The empty chair is in different rooms. The empty chair in the kitchen is the chair where the person used to sit. The empty chair in the kitchen is the chair that is the absence of the person at the meal. The empty chair in the kitchen is the chair that is the work of the year.

The empty chair in the car is the chair that is the absence of the person in the passenger seat. The empty chair in the car is the chair that is the work of the year.

The empty chair in the bedroom is the chair that is the absence of the person in the morning. The empty chair in the bedroom is the chair that is the work of the year.

The empty chair in the living room is the chair that is the absence of the person in the evening. The empty chair in the living room is the chair that is the work of the year.

The empty chair in different rooms is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Empty Chair**

The empty chair is hard. The empty chair is supposed to be hard. The empty chair is the work of the year. The year is the work.

The empty chair is not the end. The empty chair is the beginning. The empty chair is the chair that begins the work. The work is the year.

The empty chair is the chair that is the absence. The absence is the work. The work is the year.

The empty chair is the chair that is the love. The love is the work. The work is the year.

The empty chair is the chair. The chair is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The empty chair is hard. The empty chair is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the chair. The chair is the work. The work is the year.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.
2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.
3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 3: The First Three Months

The first three months are the hardest months. The first three months are the months when the grief is the most intense. The first three months are the months when the absence is the most present. The first three months are the months when the air is the thickest. The first three months are the months of the work.

The first three months are not a sentence. The first three months are the beginning. The first three months are the foundation of the year. The first three months are the work.

The first three months are also the months of the most help. The first three months are the months when the casseroles are still coming. The first three months are the months when the phone is still ringing. The first three months are the months when the friends are still checking in. The first three months are the months of the help. The help is the work.

The first three months are the months of the most grief. The first three months are the months of the most tears. The first three months are the months of the most sleeping. The first three months are the months of the most not-eating. The first three months are the months of the most doing-the-things. The first three months are the months of the work.

The first three months are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# **The First Month: The Shock Month**

The first month is the shock month. The first month is the month when the body is in shock. The first month is the month when the mind is in shock. The first month is the month when the heart is in shock. The first month is the month of the shock. The shock is the work.

The first month has 5 features:

1. The shock. The shock is the body's response to the loss. The shock is the work.
2. The numbness. The numbness is the mind's response to the loss. The numbness is the work.
3. The sleeping. The sleeping is the body's way of processing. The sleeping is the work.
4. The crying. The crying is the heart's response. The crying is the work.
5. The doing-the-things. The doing-the-things is the mind's way of coping. The doing-the-things is the work.

The first month is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The first month is not the time for big decisions. The first month is the time for breathing. The breathing is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Second Month: The Reality Month**

The second month is the reality month. The second month is the month when the shock is fading. The second month is the month when the reality is setting in. The second month is the month when the absence is becoming the air. The second month is the month of the reality. The reality is the work.

The second month has 5 features:

1. The reality. The reality is the loss. The loss is the work.
2. The anger. The anger is the heart's response. The anger is the work.
3. The bargaining. The bargaining is the mind's response. The bargaining is the work.
4. The sadness. The sadness is the body's response. The sadness is the work.
5. The doing-the-things. The doing-the-things is the work. The work is the year.

The second month is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The second month is the time for the conversations. The conversations are the work. The work is the year.

## **The Third Month: The Turning Month**

The third month is the turning month. The third month is the month when the shock is gone. The third month is the month when the reality is here. The third month is the month when the work is beginning. The third month is the month of the turning. The turning is the work.

The third month has 5 features:

1. The turning. The turning is the change. The change is the work. The work is the year.
2. The grief. The grief is the work. The work is the year.
3. The acceptance. The acceptance is the mind's response. The acceptance is the work.
4. The hope. The hope is the heart's response. The hope is the work.
5. The doing-the-things. The doing-the-things is the work. The work is the year.

The third month is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The third month is the time for the small decisions. The small decisions are the work. The work is the year.

## **The Five Things to Do in the First Three Months**

The first three months have five things. The five things are the things to do. The five things are:

1. Sleep. Sleep is the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the year.
2. Eat. Eat is the body. The body is the work. The work is the year.
3. Breathe. Breathe is the air. The air is the work. The work is the year.
4. Move. Move is the body. The body is the work. The work is the year.
5. Connect. Connect is the heart. The heart is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Not Do in the First Three Months**

The first three months have five things. The five things are the things to not do. The five things are:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later. The later is the work. The work is the year.
2. Do not move. Move is for later. The later is the work. The work is the year.
3. Do not throw away the things. The things are the work. The work is the year.
4. Do not start dating. Dating is for later. The later is the work. The work is the year.
5. Do not do the big cleaning. The big cleaning is for later. The later is the work. The work is the year.

The five things to not do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Help That Comes in the First Three Months**

The first three months have help. The help comes in different forms. The help is the work.

The help is the casseroles. The casseroles are the work. The work is the year.

The help is the phone calls. The phone calls are the work. The work is the year.

The help is the visits. The visits are the work. The work is the year.

The help is the cards. The cards are the work. The work is the year.

The help is the flowers. The flowers are the work. The work is the year.

The help is the conversations. The conversations are the work. The work is the year.

The help is the silence. The silence is the work. The work is the year.

The help is the presence. The presence is the work. The work is the year.

The help is the gift. The gift is the year.

## **A Note on the First Three Months**

The first three months are hard. The first three months are supposed to be hard. The first three months are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The first three months are not the end. The first three months are the beginning. The first three months are the months that begin the work. The work is the year.

The first three months are the months of the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the air. The air is the grief. The grief is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The first three months are hard. The first three months are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the air. The air is the work. The work is the year.

## Today's Action

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.
2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.
3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# **Chapter 4: The Friends Who Show Up (And the Ones Who Don't)**

The first year has two kinds of friends. The friends who show up and the friends who don't. The two kinds are the work of the year. The work is the year.

The friends who show up are the friends who are there. The friends who show up are the friends who call. The friends who show up are the friends who bring the food. The friends who show up are the friends who check in. The friends who show up are the friends who listen. The friends who show up are the friends who are the work. The work is the year.

The friends who don't show up are the friends who disappear. The friends who don't show up are the friends who don't call. The friends who don't show up are the friends who are uncomfortable. The friends who don't show up are the friends who don't know what to say. The friends who don't show up are the friends who are the work. The work is the year.

Both kinds of friends are the work. The work is the year.

## **The Friends Who Show Up**

The friends who show up are the gift. The friends who show up are the people who are there. The friends who show up are the people who make the work possible. The friends who show up are the work.

The friends who show up have 5 features:

1. They call. They call. The call is the work. The work is the year.

2. They bring food. They bring food. The food is the work. The work is the year.

3. They check in. They check in. The check in is the work. The work is the year.

4. They listen. They listen. The listening is the work. The work is the year.

5. They don't fix. They don't fix. The not-fixing is the work. The work is the year.

The five features are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Friends Who Don't Show Up**

The friends who don't show up are the wound. The friends who don't show up are the people who were not there. The friends who don't show up are the work.

The friends who don't show up have 5 features:

1. They don't call. They don't call. The not-calling is the work. The work is the year.

2. They avoid. They avoid. The avoiding is the work. The work is the year.

3. They change the subject. They change the subject. The changing is the work. The work is the year.

4. They say the wrong things. They say the wrong things. The wrong things are the work. The work is the year.

5. They disappear. They disappear. The disappearing is the work. The work is the year.

The five features are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Do With the Friends Who Show Up**

The friends who show up have five things. The five things are the things to do. The five things are:

1. Say thank you. Say thank you. The thank you is the work. The work is the year.
2. Accept the help. Accept the help. The accepting is the work. The work is the year.
3. Be specific. Be specific. The specific is the work. The work is the year.
4. Let them in. Let them in. The letting in is the work. The work is the year.
5. Stay connected. Stay connected. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Do With the Friends Who Don't Show Up**

The friends who don't show up have five things. The five things are the things to do. The five things are:

1. Grieve the friendship. Grieve the friendship. The grieving is the work. The work is the year.
2. Don't take it personally. Don't take it personally. The not-taking is the work. The work is the year.
3. Reach out once. Reach out once. The reaching is the work. The work is the year.
4. Let it be. Let it be. The letting be is the work. The work is the year.
5. Make new friends. Make new friends. The making is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Never Do With the Friends**

The friends have three things. The three things are the things to never do. The three things are:

1. Never expect the friend to know what to do. The friend doesn't know. The knowing is the work. The work is the year.
2. Never blame the friend for the loss. The friend is not the loss. The loss is the work. The work is the year.
3. Never let the friend do the work for you. The friend is the helper. The work is yours. The yours is the year.

The three things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things Friends Don't Know About Grief**

The friends have five things they don't know. The five things are the things to teach them. The five things are:

1. Grief is not a phase. Grief is not a phase. The phase is the work. The work is the year.
2. Grief is not over. Grief is not over. The over is the work. The work is the year.
3. Grief is not a problem to solve. Grief is not a problem. The problem is the work. The work is the year.

4. Grief is not the same for everyone. Grief is not the same. The same is the work. The work is the year.

5. Grief is the work of the year. Grief is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things You Can Ask Friends For**

The friends have five things you can ask for. The five things are the things to ask. The five things are:

1. A meal. A meal is the work. The work is the year.

2. A ride. A ride is the work. The work is the year.

3. A listening ear. A listening ear is the work. The work is the year.

4. A check-in. A check-in is the work. The work is the year.

5. A presence. A presence is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Friends**

The friends are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The friends who show up are the gift. The gift is the work. The work is the year.

The friends who don't show up are the wound. The wound is the work. The work is the year.

Both kinds of friends are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

You are not failing. The friends are hard. The friends are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the friends. The friends are the work. The work is the year.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.
2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.
3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 5: The Six-Month Marker

The six-month marker is the first signpost. The six-month marker is the day that is six months after the loss. The six-month marker is the day that is half the year. The six-month marker is the day that is the work of the year.

The six-month marker is hard. The six-month marker is supposed to be hard. The six-month marker is the day you realize that the loss is not going away. The six-month marker is the day you realize that the air is the air. The six-month marker is the day you realize that the work is the work. The work is the year.

The six-month marker is also the day you realize that you are still here. The six-month marker is the day you realize that the work is making a difference. The six-month marker is the day you realize that the air is the air. The six-month marker is the day that is the work of the year.

The six-month marker is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## The Three Truths of the Six-Month Marker

The six-month marker has three truths. The three truths are the foundation. The three truths are:

Truth 1: The six-month marker is supposed to be hard. The six-month marker is the day that is half the year. The half is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 2: The six-month marker is the day you realize the work is working. The work is working. The

working is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 3: The six-month marker is the day you realize you are still alive. The alive is the work. The work is the year.

The three truths are the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Five Things to Do on the Six-Month Marker**

The six-month marker has five things. The five things are the things to do. The five things are:

1. Mark the day. Mark the day. The marking is the work. The work is the year.
2. Do something for yourself. Do something for yourself. The yourself is the work. The work is the year.
3. Be with someone you love. Be with someone you love. The love is the work. The work is the year.
4. Reflect on the work. Reflect on the work. The reflecting is the work. The work is the year.
5. Plan the next six months. Plan the next six months. The planning is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Not Do on the Six-Month Marker**

The six-month marker has three things. The three things are the things to not do. The three things are:

1. Do not pretend it's just another day. It is not just another day. The day is the work. The work is the

year.

2. Do not isolate. Isolation is for later. The later is the work. The work is the year.

3. Do not do the big work. The big work is for later. The later is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to not do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Notice on the Six-Month Marker**

The six-month marker has five things. The five things are the things to notice. The five things are:

1. You are still here. You are still here. The here is the work. The work is the year.

2. You have done the work. You have done the work. The doing is the work. The work is the year.

3. The air is the air. The air is the air. The air is the work. The work is the year.

4. The friends are still here. The friends are still here. The here is the work. The work is the year.

5. The work is the work. The work is the work. The work is the year.

The five things to notice are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Six-Month Marker**

The six-month marker is hard. The six-month marker is supposed to be hard. The six-month marker is the work of the year. The year is the work.

The six-month marker is not the end. The six-month marker is the beginning of the second half. The second half is the work. The work is the year.

The six-month marker is the day you realize that the work is working. The working is the work. The work is the year.

The six-month marker is the day you realize you are still alive. The alive is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The six-month marker is hard. The six-month marker is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the air. The air is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Three Things the Six-Month Marker Is Not**

The six-month marker is not three things. The three things are the things the six-month marker is not. The three things are:

1. The end. The six-month marker is not the end. The end is the work. The work is the year.
2. The finish. The six-month marker is not the finish. The finish is the work. The work is the year.
3. The done. The six-month marker is not the done. The done is the work. The work is the year.

The three things the six-month marker is not are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things You Might Feel on the Six-Month Marker**

The six-month marker has five things you might feel. The five things are:

1. Pride. Pride is the work. The work is the year.

2. Sadness. Sadness is the work. The work is the year.

3. Loneliness. Loneliness is the work. The work is the year.

4. Hope. Hope is the work. The work is the year.

5. Continued grief. Continued grief is the work.  
The work is the year.

The five feelings are the work. The work is the year.  
The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Do on the Six-Month Marker If You Are Alone**

The six-month marker has three things to do if you are alone. The three things are:

1. Call a friend. Call a friend. The calling is the work. The work is the year.

2. Treat yourself. Treat yourself. The treating is the work. The work is the year.

3. Mark the day. Mark the day. The marking is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Six-Month Marker**

The six-month marker is hard. The six-month marker is supposed to be hard. The six-month marker is the work of the year. The year is the work.

The six-month marker is the day that you realize the work is working. The working is the work. The work is the year.

The six-month marker is the day that you realize you are still here. The here is the work. The work is the

year.

The six-month marker is the day that you realize the work is the gift. The gift is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The six-month marker is hard. The six-month marker is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.
2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.
3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 6: The Money and the Paperwork

The first year has money. The first year has paperwork. The money is the work. The paperwork is the work. The work is the year.

The money and the paperwork are the things nobody wants to talk about. The money and the paperwork are the things that have to be done. The money and the paperwork are the things that are the work of the year.

The money and the paperwork are also the things that are the most concrete. The money and the paperwork are the things that can be done when the grief is too much. The money and the paperwork are the things that are the work.

The money and the paperwork are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## The Five Money Things to Do in the First Year

The first year has five money things. The five money things are the things to do. The five money things are:

1. Find the will. Find the will. The will is the work. The work is the year.
2. Find the insurance policies. Find the insurance policies. The policies are the work. The work is the year.
3. Find the bank accounts. Find the bank accounts. The accounts are the work. The work is the year.
4. Find the retirement accounts. Find the retirement accounts. The accounts are the work.

The work is the year.

5. Find the deeds and titles. Find the deeds and titles. The titles are the work. The work is the year.

The five money things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Paperwork Things to Do in the First Year**

The first year has five paperwork things. The five paperwork things are the things to do. The five paperwork things are:

1. File the death certificate copies. File the death certificate copies. The filing is the work. The work is the year.

2. Notify Social Security. Notify Social Security. The notifying is the work. The work is the year.

3. Notify the bank. Notify the bank. The notifying is the work. The work is the year.

4. Notify the insurance. Notify the insurance. The notifying is the work. The work is the year.

5. Notify the retirement. Notify the retirement. The notifying is the work. The work is the year.

The five paperwork things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Not Do With the Money**

The money has three things. The three things are the things to not do. The three things are:

1. Do not make big financial decisions in the first six months. The big decisions are for later. The later is the work. The work is the year.

2. Do not give money to anyone who pressures you. The pressure is not the work. The work is the year.

3. Do not sign anything you do not understand. The understanding is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to not do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three People to Hire in the First Year**

The first year has three people. The three people are the people to hire. The three people are:

1. An accountant. An accountant. The accounting is the work. The work is the year.

2. A financial advisor. A financial advisor. The advising is the work. The work is the year.

3. An estate attorney. An estate attorney. The estate is the work. The work is the year.

The three people are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Documents to Organize**

The first year has five documents. The five documents are the documents to organize. The five documents are:

1. The will. The will. The will is the work. The work is the year.

2. The trust. The trust. The trust is the work. The work is the year.

3. The life insurance. The life insurance. The insurance is the work. The work is the year.

4. The health insurance. The health insurance. The insurance is the work. The work is the year.

5. The bank accounts. The bank accounts. The accounts are the work. The work is the year.

The five documents are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Money and the Paperwork**

The money and the paperwork are hard. The money and the paperwork are supposed to be hard. The money and the paperwork are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The money and the paperwork are not the end. The money and the paperwork are the beginning. The money and the paperwork are the work that begins the year. The year is the work.

The money and the paperwork are the things that are the most concrete. The concrete is the work. The work is the year.

The money and the paperwork are the things that can be done when the grief is too much. The doing is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The money and the paperwork are hard. The money and the paperwork are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Documents to Find First**

The first three months have three documents. The three documents are the documents to find first. The three documents are:

1. The will. The will is the work. The work is the year.
2. The insurance. The insurance is the work. The work is the year.
3. The bank accounts. The bank accounts are the work. The work is the year.

The three documents are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Tell the Bank**

The bank has three things. The three things are the things to tell the bank. The three things are:

1. The death. The death is the work. The work is the year.
2. The next steps. The next steps are the work. The work is the year.
3. The account access. The account access is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to tell the bank are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Tell the Insurance**

The insurance has three things. The three things are the things to tell the insurance. The three things are:

1. The death. The death is the work. The work is the year.

2. The policy number. The policy number is the work. The work is the year.

3. The next steps. The next steps are the work. The work is the year.

The three things to tell the insurance are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Tell Social Security**

Social Security has three things. The three things are the things to tell Social Security. The three things are:

1. The death. The death is the work. The work is the year.

2. The Social Security number. The Social Security number is the work. The work is the year.

3. The next steps. The next steps are the work. The work is the year.

The three things to tell Social Security are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Money and the Paperwork**

The money and the paperwork are hard. The money and the paperwork are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The money and the paperwork are not the end. The money and the paperwork are the beginning. The money and the paperwork are the work that begins the year. The year is the work.

The money and the paperwork are the things that are the most concrete. The concrete is the work. The work is the year.

The money and the paperwork are the things that can be done when the grief is too much. The doing is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The money and the paperwork are hard. The money and the paperwork are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.
2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.
3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 7: The Grief That Comes in Waves

The grief comes in waves. The grief is not a line. The grief is not a curve. The grief is a wave. The wave is the work.

The wave is the metaphor that grief specialists use most. The wave is the metaphor that captures the experience of the first year. The wave is the work.

The wave has a structure. The wave has a beginning. The wave has a peak. The wave has an end. The wave has a rhythm. The wave is the work.

The wave is not predictable. The wave is not controllable. The wave is not stoppable. The wave is the work. The work is the year.

The wave is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## The Five Triggers of the Wave

The wave has five triggers. The five triggers are the things that bring the wave. The five triggers are:

1. The smell. The smell. The smell is the work. The work is the year.
2. The song. The song. The song is the work. The work is the year.
3. The place. The place. The place is the work. The work is the year.
4. The date. The date. The date is the work. The work is the year.
5. The memory. The memory. The memory is the work. The work is the year.

The five triggers are the work. The work is the year.  
The year is the gift.

## **The Five Stages of the Wave**

The wave has five stages. The five stages are the things that happen during the wave. The five stages are:

1. The trigger. The trigger. The triggering is the work. The work is the year.
2. The buildup. The buildup. The building up is the work. The work is the year.
3. The peak. The peak. The peaking is the work. The work is the year.
4. The crash. The crash. The crashing is the work. The work is the year.
5. The after. The after. The after is the work. The work is the year.

The five stages are the work. The work is the year.  
The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Do in the Wave**

The wave has five things. The five things are the things to do. The five things are:

1. Breathe. Breathe. The breathing is the work. The work is the year.
2. Ground yourself. Ground yourself. The grounding is the work. The work is the year.
3. Let it come. Let it come. The letting is the work. The work is the year.
4. Let it go. Let it go. The letting is the work. The work is the year.

5. Be with someone. Be with someone. The being is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Not Do in the Wave**

The wave has three things. The three things are the things to not do. The three things are:

1. Do not fight the wave. The fighting is not the work. The work is the year.
2. Do not run from the wave. The running is not the work. The work is the year.
3. Do not judge the wave. The judging is not the work. The work is the year.

The three things to not do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Build for the Wave**

The wave has five things. The five things are the things to build. The five things are:

1. The support system. The support system. The system is the work. The work is the year.
2. The safe place. The safe place. The place is the work. The work is the year.
3. The self-care practice. The self-care practice. The practice is the work. The work is the year.
4. The professional help. The professional help. The help is the work. The work is the year.
5. The meaning-making. The meaning-making. The making is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Wave**

The wave is hard. The wave is supposed to be hard. The wave is the work of the year. The year is the work.

The wave is not the end. The wave is the beginning. The wave is the work that begins the year. The year is the work.

The wave is the air. The air is the work. The work is the year.

The wave is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

You are not failing. The wave is hard. The wave is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the wave. The wave is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Three Types of Grief Waves**

The grief waves have three types. The three types are the kinds of waves. The three types are:

1. The surprise wave. The surprise wave is the wave you didn't see coming. The wave is the work. The work is the year.
2. The trigger wave. The trigger wave is the wave that comes from a trigger. The wave is the work. The work is the year.
3. The anniversary wave. The anniversary wave is the wave that comes on a date. The wave is the work. The work is the year.

The three types of waves are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Remember About the Waves**

The waves have three things. The three things are the things to remember. The three things are:

1. The waves are not a setback. The waves are not a setback. The setback is the work. The work is the year.
2. The waves are part of the work. The waves are part of the work. The work is the year.
3. The waves will get less intense. The waves will get less intense. The intensity is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to remember are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Do When a Wave Comes**

The waves have three things to do. The three things are the things to do. The three things are:

1. Stop. Stop. The stopping is the work. The work is the year.
2. Breathe. Breathe. The breathing is the work. The work is the year.
3. Let it pass. Let it pass. The passing is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Wave**

The wave is hard. The wave is the work of the year.  
The year is the work.

The wave is the air. The air is the work. The work is the year.

The wave is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

You are not failing. The wave is hard. The wave is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.  
The year is the gift.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.
2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.
3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 8: The Sleep That Won't Come

The first year has sleep problems. The first year has nights that are long. The first year has mornings that come too soon. The first year has the work of the sleep.

The sleep is the foundation. The sleep is the body's way of processing. The sleep is the body's way of healing. The sleep is the work.

When the sleep is broken, the work is harder. When the sleep is gone, the work is harder. When the sleep is the enemy, the work is harder. The work is the year.

The sleep is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## The Five Reasons the Sleep Won't Come

The sleep has five reasons. The five reasons are the things that keep the sleep from coming. The five reasons are:

1. The grief. The grief. The grieving is the work. The work is the year.
2. The fear. The fear. The fearing is the work. The work is the year.
3. The loneliness. The loneliness. The being alone is the work. The work is the year.
4. The overthinking. The overthinking. The thinking is the work. The work is the year.
5. The body. The body. The body is the work. The work is the year.

The five reasons are the work. The work is the year.  
The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Do for the Sleep**

The sleep has five things. The five things are the things to do. The five things are:

1. Have a bedtime routine. Have a bedtime routine. The routine is the work. The work is the year.
2. Avoid screens before bed. Avoid screens before bed. The avoiding is the work. The work is the year.
3. Avoid caffeine after 2 PM. Avoid caffeine after 2 PM. The avoiding is the work. The work is the year.
4. Have a worry journal. Have a worry journal. The journaling is the work. The work is the year.
5. Talk to a doctor if the sleep is gone for more than 3 months. Talk to a doctor. The talking is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Not Do for the Sleep**

The sleep has five things. The five things are the things to not do. The five things are:

1. Do not lie in bed awake for more than 20 minutes. The lying is not the work. The work is the year.
2. Do not use alcohol to sleep. The alcohol is not the work. The work is the year.

3. Do not watch the clock. The watching is not the work. The work is the year.

4. Do not take naps longer than 30 minutes. The napping is not the work. The work is the year.

5. Do not give up. The giving up is not the work. The work is the year.

The five things to not do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Routines for the Sleep**

The sleep has five routines. The five routines are the routines to build. The five routines are:

1. The 10 PM wind-down. The 10 PM wind-down. The wind-down is the work. The work is the year.

2. The dim lights. The dim lights. The dimming is the work. The work is the year.

3. The hot shower. The hot shower. The showering is the work. The work is the year.

4. The reading. The reading. The reading is the work. The work is the year.

5. The bed. The bed. The bedding is the work. The work is the year.

The five routines are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Sleep**

The sleep is hard. The sleep is supposed to be hard. The sleep is the work of the year. The year is the work.

The sleep is not the end. The sleep is the beginning. The sleep is the work that begins the year. The year is the work.

The sleep is the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the year.

The sleep is the gift. The gift is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The sleep is hard. The sleep is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the sleep. The sleep is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Three Things to Do for Better Sleep**

The sleep has three things to do for better sleep. The three things are:

1. Have a bedtime routine. Have a bedtime routine. The routine is the work. The work is the year.
2. Avoid screens before bed. Avoid screens. The avoiding is the work. The work is the year.
3. Avoid caffeine after 2 PM. Avoid caffeine. The avoiding is the work. The work is the year.

The three things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things That Disturb the Sleep**

The sleep has three things that disturb. The three things are:

1. The grief. The grief is the work. The work is the year.

2. The overthinking. The overthinking is the work.  
The work is the year.

3. The body clock. The body clock is the work. The  
work is the year.

The three things that disturb are the work. The work  
is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Try Before Sleeping Pills**

The sleep has three things to try before sleeping pills.  
The three things are:

1. The bedtime routine. The bedtime routine is the  
work. The work is the year.

2. The relaxation exercise. The relaxation exercise  
is the work. The work is the year.

3. The warm shower. The warm shower is the  
work. The work is the year.

The three things to try are the work. The work is the  
year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Sleep**

The sleep is hard. The sleep is the work of the year.  
The year is the work.

The sleep is the foundation. The foundation is the  
work. The work is the year.

The sleep is the gift. The gift is the work. The work is  
the year.

You are not failing. The sleep is hard. The sleep is the  
work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.  
The year is the gift.

## Today's Action

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.
2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.
3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 9: The Eating and the Body

The first year has eating problems. The first year has body problems. The first year has the work of the eating. The first year has the work of the body.

The eating is the foundation. The eating is the body's way of staying alive. The eating is the body's way of healing. The eating is the work.

When the eating is broken, the work is harder. When the eating is gone, the work is harder. When the eating is the enemy, the work is harder. The work is the year.

The eating is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## The Five Eating Problems

The eating has five problems. The five problems are the things that happen. The five problems are:

1. Not eating. Not eating. The not-eating is the work. The work is the year.
2. Eating too much. Eating too much. The too-much is the work. The work is the year.
3. Eating the wrong things. Eating the wrong things. The wrong is the work. The work is the year.
4. Eating at the wrong times. Eating at the wrong times. The wrong is the work. The work is the year.
5. Not enjoying the food. Not enjoying the food. The not-enjoying is the work. The work is the year.

The five problems are the work. The work is the year.  
The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Do for the Eating**

The eating has five things. The five things are the things to do. The five things are:

1. Eat three meals a day. Eat three meals a day. The eating is the work. The work is the year.
2. Eat one thing you love each day. Eat one thing you love each day. The loving is the work. The work is the year.
3. Drink water. Drink water. The drinking is the work. The work is the year.
4. Have a mealtime. Have a mealtime. The mealtime is the work. The work is the year.
5. Talk to a doctor if the eating is gone for more than 3 months. Talk to a doctor. The talking is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Not Do for the Eating**

The eating has five things. The five things are the things to not do. The five things are:

1. Do not skip meals to save time for grief. The grief is not the work. The work is the year.
2. Do not eat to numb the grief. The numbing is not the work. The work is the year.
3. Do not judge the eating. The judging is not the work. The work is the year.

4. Do not give up on the food. The giving up is not the work. The work is the year.

5. Do not eat the same thing every day. The same is not the work. The work is the year.

The five things to not do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Body Things to Do**

The body has five things. The five things are the things to do. The five things are:

1. Walk 30 minutes a day. Walk 30 minutes a day. The walking is the work. The work is the year.

2. Stretch 10 minutes a day. Stretch 10 minutes a day. The stretching is the work. The work is the year.

3. Get 7-8 hours of sleep. Get 7-8 hours of sleep. The sleeping is the work. The work is the year.

4. See a doctor for a checkup. See a doctor. The seeing is the work. The work is the year.

5. See a therapist for the grief. See a therapist. The seeing is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Eating and the Body**

The eating and the body are hard. The eating and the body are supposed to be hard. The eating and the body are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The eating and the body are not the end. The eating and the body are the beginning. The eating and the body are the work that begins the year. The year is the work.

The eating and the body are the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the year.

The eating and the body are the gift. The gift is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The eating and the body are hard. The eating and the body are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the eating. The eating is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Three Reasons the Eating Is Hard**

The eating has three reasons. The three reasons are:

1. The grief. The grief is the work. The work is the year.
2. The lack of appetite. The lack of appetite is the work. The work is the year.
3. The lack of motivation. The lack of motivation is the work. The work is the year.

The three reasons are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Do for Better Eating**

The eating has three things to do for better eating. The three things are:

1. Eat three meals a day. Eat three meals. The eating is the work. The work is the year.
2. Have snacks ready. Have snacks ready. The having is the work. The work is the year.

3. Drink water. Drink water. The drinking is the work. The work is the year.

The three things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Try if You Are Not Eating**

The eating has three things to try. The three things are:

1. Have easy-to-eat food. Have easy food. The having is the work. The work is the year.
2. Have a meal with someone. Have a meal. The having is the work. The work is the year.
3. Have a routine. Have a routine. The having is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to try are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Eating and the Body**

The eating and the body are hard. The eating and the body are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The eating and the body are the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the year.

The eating and the body are the gift. The gift is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The eating and the body are hard. The eating and the body are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## Today's Action

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.
2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.
3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 10: The Holidays and the Anniversaries

The first year has holidays. The first year has anniversaries. The first year has the work of the holidays. The first year has the work of the anniversaries.

The holidays and the anniversaries are the days that are the most visible. The holidays and the anniversaries are the days that are the most public. The holidays and the anniversaries are the days that are the most painful. The holidays and the anniversaries are the days that are the work of the year.

The holidays and the anniversaries are also the days that are the most important. The holidays and the anniversaries are the days that are the most meaningful. The holidays and the anniversaries are the days that are the most honoring. The holidays and the anniversaries are the days that are the work.

The holidays and the anniversaries are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## The Five Holidays of the First Year

The first year has five holidays. The five holidays are the most important. The five holidays are:

1. The birthday. The birthday. The birthday is the work. The work is the year.
2. The wedding anniversary. The wedding anniversary. The anniversary is the work. The work is the year.

3. The holidays (Thanksgiving, Christmas, etc.).  
The holidays. The holidays are the work. The work  
is the year.

4. The death anniversary. The death anniversary.  
The anniversary is the work. The work is the year.

5. The new year. The new year. The new year is  
the work. The work is the year.

The five holidays are the work. The work is the year.  
The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Do for the Holidays**

The holidays have five things. The five things are the  
things to do. The five things are:

1. Plan ahead. Plan ahead. The planning is the  
work. The work is the year.

2. Be with people you love. Be with people you  
love. The loving is the work. The work is the year.

3. Create a new tradition. Create a new tradition.  
The creating is the work. The work is the year.

4. Honor the person. Honor the person. The  
honoring is the work. The work is the year.

5. Have an exit plan. Have an exit plan. The  
planning is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The  
year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Not Do for the Holidays**

The holidays have three things. The three things are  
the things to not do. The three things are:

1. Do not pretend the person is not gone. The pretending is not the work. The work is the year.
2. Do not isolate. The isolating is not the work. The work is the year.
3. Do not try to do everything the way you used to. The trying is not the work. The work is the year.

The three things to not do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Do for the Anniversaries**

The anniversaries have five things. The five things are the things to do. The five things are:

1. Mark the day. Mark the day. The marking is the work. The work is the year.
2. Do something for yourself. Do something for yourself. The yourself is the work. The work is the year.
3. Be with someone you love. Be with someone you love. The love is the work. The work is the year.
4. Honor the person. Honor the person. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.
5. Reflect on the year. Reflect on the year. The reflecting is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Not Do for the Anniversaries**

The anniversaries have three things. The three things are the things to not do. The three things are:

1. Do not pretend the day is just another day. The pretending is not the work. The work is the year.
2. Do not be alone if you do not want to be. The alone is not the work. The work is the year.
3. Do not do the big work. The big work is for later. The later is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to not do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Holidays and the Anniversaries**

The holidays and the anniversaries are hard. The holidays and the anniversaries are supposed to be hard. The holidays and the anniversaries are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The holidays and the anniversaries are not the end. The holidays and the anniversaries are the beginning. The holidays and the anniversaries are the work that begins the year. The year is the work.

The holidays and the anniversaries are the days that are the most meaningful. The meaningful is the work. The work is the year.

The holidays and the anniversaries are the days that are the most honoring. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The holidays and the anniversaries are hard. The holidays and the anniversaries are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the holidays. The holidays are the work. The work is the year.

## **The Three Things to Do for the First Birthday Without Them**

The first birthday has three things to do. The three things are:

1. Mark the day. Mark the day. The marking is the work. The work is the year.
2. Be with someone. Be with someone. The being is the work. The work is the year.
3. Do something for yourself. Do something for yourself. The doing is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Do for the First Christmas Without Them**

The first Christmas has three things to do. The three things are:

1. Plan ahead. Plan ahead. The planning is the work. The work is the year.
2. Create a new tradition. Create a new tradition. The creating is the work. The work is the year.
3. Honor the person. Honor the person. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Do for the Death Anniversary**

The death anniversary has three things to do. The three things are:

1. Mark the day. Mark the day. The marking is the work. The work is the year.

2. Be with someone. Be with someone. The being is the work. The work is the year.

3. Honor the person. Honor the person. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Holidays and the Anniversaries**

The holidays and the anniversaries are hard. The holidays and the anniversaries are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The holidays and the anniversaries are the days that are the most meaningful. The meaningful is the work. The work is the year.

The holidays and the anniversaries are the days that are the most honoring. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The holidays and the anniversaries are hard. The holidays and the anniversaries are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.

2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.

3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.

2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.

3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 11: The Family and the Adult Children

The first year has family. The first year has adult children. The first year has the work of the family. The first year has the work of the adult children.

The family and the adult children are the people who are the closest. The family and the adult children are the people who are the most loving. The family and the adult children are the people who are the most helpful. The family and the adult children are the people who are the work of the year.

The family and the adult children are also the people who are the most complicated. The family and the adult children are the people who are the most emotional. The family and the adult children are the people who are the most triggering. The family and the adult children are the people who are the work.

The family and the adult children are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## The Five Roles of the Family in the First Year

The family has five roles. The five roles are the things the family does. The five roles are:

1. The supporter. The supporter. The supporting is the work. The work is the year.
2. The helper. The helper. The helping is the work. The work is the year.
3. The listener. The listener. The listening is the work. The work is the year.

4. The check-in-er. The check-in-er. The checking in is the work. The work is the year.

5. The presence. The presence. The being present is the work. The work is the year.

The five roles are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things the Adult Children Need**

The adult children have five needs. The five needs are the things they need. The five needs are:

1. The honesty. The honesty. The being honest is the work. The work is the year.

2. The presence. The presence. The being present is the work. The work is the year.

3. The boundaries. The boundaries. The having boundaries is the work. The work is the year.

4. The space. The space. The giving space is the work. The work is the year.

5. The help when asked. The help when asked. The helping is the work. The work is the year.

The five needs are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Talk About With the Adult Children**

The adult children have five things. The five things are the things to talk about. The five things are:

1. The grief. The grief. The talking is the work. The work is the year.

2. The money. The money. The talking is the work. The work is the year.

3. The future. The future. The talking is the work.  
The work is the year.

4. The home. The home. The talking is the work.  
The work is the year.

5. The relationships. The relationships. The talking  
is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The  
year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Not Do With the Adult Children**

The adult children have three things. The three things  
are the things to not do. The three things are:

1. Do not lean on them too much. The leaning is  
not the work. The work is the year.

2. Do not shut them out. The shutting out is not the  
work. The work is the year.

3. Do not make them your therapist. The making is  
not the work. The work is the year.

The three things to not do are the work. The work is  
the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Do With the Family**

The family has five things. The five things are the  
things to do. The five things are:

1. Have a weekly check-in. Have a weekly  
check-in. The checking in is the work. The work is  
the year.

2. Have a monthly meal together. Have a monthly  
meal together. The eating is the work. The work is  
the year.

3. Be honest about the grief. Be honest. The honesty is the work. The work is the year.

4. Ask for help when you need it. Ask for help. The asking is the work. The work is the year.

5. Let them help when they offer. Let them help. The letting is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Family and the Adult Children**

The family and the adult children are hard. The family and the adult children are supposed to be hard. The family and the adult children are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The family and the adult children are not the end. The family and the adult children are the beginning. The family and the adult children are the work that begins the year. The year is the work.

The family and the adult children are the people who are the closest. The closest is the work. The work is the year.

The family and the adult children are the people who are the most loving. The loving is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The family and the adult children are hard. The family and the adult children are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the family. The family is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Three Conversations to Have With the Adult Children**

The adult children have three conversations. The three conversations are:

1. The grief conversation. The grief conversation is the work. The work is the year.
2. The money conversation. The money conversation is the work. The work is the year.
3. The future conversation. The future conversation is the work. The work is the year.

The three conversations are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things the Adult Children Need to Hear**

The adult children have three things they need to hear. The three things are:

1. "I am okay." I am okay. The okay is the work. The work is the year.
2. "I need you." I need you. The needing is the work. The work is the year.
3. "I love you." I love you. The loving is the work. The work is the year.

The three things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Not Do With the Adult Children**

The adult children have three things to not do. The three things are:

1. Do not lean on them too much. The leaning is not the work. The work is the year.
2. Do not shut them out. The shutting out is not the work. The work is the year.
3. Do not make them your therapist. The making is not the work. The work is the year.

The three things to not do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Family and the Adult Children**

The family and the adult children are hard. The family and the adult children are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The family and the adult children are the people who are the closest. The closest is the work. The work is the year.

The family and the adult children are the people who are the most loving. The loving is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The family and the adult children are hard. The family and the adult children are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.

2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.

3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.

2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.

3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 12: The First Anniversary

The first anniversary is the most important day of the year. The first anniversary is the day that is one year after the loss. The first anniversary is the day that is the first marker of the long life. The first anniversary is the day that is the work of the year.

The first anniversary is hard. The first anniversary is supposed to be hard. The first anniversary is the day you realize that the year is done. The first anniversary is the day you realize that the work of the year is done. The first anniversary is the day you realize that the next year is beginning. The first anniversary is the day that is the work.

The first anniversary is also the day you realize that you are still here. The first anniversary is the day you realize that the work has made a difference. The first anniversary is the day you realize that the air is the air. The first anniversary is the day that is the work of the year.

The first anniversary is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## The Five Truths of the First Anniversary

The first anniversary has five truths. The five truths are the foundation. The five truths are:

Truth 1: The first anniversary is supposed to be hard. The first anniversary is the day that is one year. The one year is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 2: The first anniversary is the day you realize the work is done. The work is done. The done is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 3: The first anniversary is the day you realize you are still here. The here is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 4: The first anniversary is the day you honor the person. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 5: The first anniversary is the day you look forward. The looking forward is the work. The work is the year.

The five truths are the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Five Things to Do on the First Anniversary**

The first anniversary has five things. The five things are the things to do. The five things are:

1. Mark the day. Mark the day. The marking is the work. The work is the year.
2. Honor the person. Honor the person. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.
3. Be with people you love. Be with people you love. The love is the work. The work is the year.
4. Reflect on the year. Reflect on the year. The reflecting is the work. The work is the year.
5. Plan the next year. Plan the next year. The planning is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Ways to Honor the Person on the First Anniversary**

The first anniversary has five ways. The five ways are the ways to honor the person. The five ways are:

1. Light a candle. Light a candle. The lighting is the work. The work is the year.
2. Visit the grave or the place. Visit the grave or the place. The visiting is the work. The work is the year.
3. Tell a story. Tell a story. The telling is the work. The work is the year.
4. Do something they loved. Do something they loved. The doing is the work. The work is the year.
5. Donate to a cause they cared about. Donate. The donating is the work. The work is the year.

The five ways are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Not Do on the First Anniversary**

The first anniversary has three things. The three things are the things to not do. The three things are:

1. Do not pretend it's just another day. The pretending is not the work. The work is the year.
2. Do not isolate. The isolating is not the work. The work is the year.
3. Do not be with people who make it harder. The harder is not the work. The work is the year.

The three things to not do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the First Anniversary**

The first anniversary is hard. The first anniversary is supposed to be hard. The first anniversary is the work of the year. The year is the work.

The first anniversary is not the end. The first anniversary is the beginning. The first anniversary is the day that begins the next year. The next year is the work.

The first anniversary is the day that is the most meaningful. The meaningful is the work. The work is the year.

The first anniversary is the day that is the most honoring. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The first anniversary is hard. The first anniversary is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the first anniversary. The first anniversary is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Three Things to Do for Yourself on the First Anniversary**

The first anniversary has three things to do for yourself. The three things are:

1. Treat yourself. Treat yourself. The treating is the work. The work is the year.
2. Do something you love. Do something you love. The doing is the work. The work is the year.
3. Be with someone you love. Be with someone you love. The being is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Do for the Person on the First Anniversary**

The first anniversary has three things to do for the person. The three things are:

1. Light a candle. Light a candle. The lighting is the work. The work is the year.
2. Tell a story. Tell a story. The telling is the work. The work is the year.
3. Visit the place. Visit the place. The visiting is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Do for the Future on the First Anniversary**

The first anniversary has three things to do for the future. The three things are:

1. Set a goal. Set a goal. The setting is the work. The work is the year.
2. Make a plan. Make a plan. The making is the work. The work is the year.
3. Have hope. Have hope. The having is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the First Anniversary**

The first anniversary is hard. The first anniversary is the work of the year. The year is the work.

The first anniversary is the day that is the most meaningful. The meaningful is the work. The work is the year.

The first anniversary is the day that is the most honoring. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The first anniversary is hard. The first anniversary is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.
2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.
3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 13: The Dating Question

The first year has the dating question. The first year has the question: should I date? The first year has the question: when do I date? The first year has the question: how do I date? The first year has the work of the dating question.

The dating question is one of the most controversial questions in the first year. The dating question is one of the most personal questions in the first year. The dating question is one of the most emotional questions in the first year. The dating question is the work.

The dating question is also one of the most avoided questions. The dating question is one of the most whispered questions. The dating question is one of the most judged questions. The dating question is the work.

The dating question is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## The Five Truths About the Dating Question

The dating question has five truths. The five truths are the foundation. The five truths are:

Truth 1: The dating question is personal. The dating question is yours. The yours is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 2: The dating question has no right answer. The right answer is yours. The yours is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 3: The dating question is not a betrayal. The dating is not the betrayal. The betrayal is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 4: The dating question is not a sign of being over the grief. The dating is not the over. The over is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 5: The dating question is the work. The dating is the work. The work is the year.

The five truths are the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Five Signs You Are Ready to Date**

The dating has five signs. The five signs are the signs you are ready. The five signs are:

1. You can talk about the person without falling apart. The talking is the work. The work is the year.
2. You can be alone and be okay with it. The being alone is the work. The work is the year.
3. You can imagine being with someone new. The imagining is the work. The work is the year.
4. You can let go of the idea of finding another person like them. The letting go is the work. The work is the year.
5. You can date for connection, not for grief. The dating is the work. The work is the year.

The five signs are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# **The Five Signs You Are Not Ready to Date**

The dating has five signs. The five signs are the signs you are not ready. The five signs are:

1. You are dating to avoid the grief. The avoiding is not the work. The work is the year.
2. You are looking for the person to replace the person. The replacing is not the work. The work is the year.
3. You are dating because someone is pressuring you. The pressuring is not the work. The work is the year.
4. You cannot be alone. The alone is not the work. The work is the year.
5. You are still in the deep grief. The deep is not the work. The work is the year.

The five signs are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# **The Five Tips for Dating After the First Year**

The dating has five tips. The five tips are the tips for dating. The five tips are:

1. Be honest about being widowed. Be honest. The honesty is the work. The work is the year.
2. Take it slow. Take it slow. The slow is the work. The work is the year.
3. Have the difficult conversations early. Have the difficult conversations. The conversations are the work. The work is the year.
4. Honor the person you lost. Honor the person. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.

5. Give yourself permission to be happy. Give yourself permission. The permission is the work. The work is the year.

The five tips are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Dating Question**

The dating question is hard. The dating question is supposed to be hard. The dating question is the work of the year. The year is the work.

The dating question is not the end. The dating question is the beginning. The dating question is the work that begins the year. The year is the work.

The dating question is the question that is the most personal. The personal is the work. The work is the year.

The dating question is the question that is the most emotional. The emotional is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The dating question is hard. The dating question is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the dating. The dating is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Three Signs You Are Not Ready to Date Yet**

The dating has three signs you are not ready. The three signs are:

1. You are dating to avoid the grief. The avoiding is not the work. The work is the year.

2. You are looking for a replacement. The replacing is not the work. The work is the year.
3. You cannot be alone. The alone is not the work. The work is the year.

The three signs are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Do Before You Start Dating**

The dating has three things to do before you start. The three things are:

1. Complete the grief work. Complete the grief work. The completing is the work. The work is the year.
2. Be okay being alone. Be okay being alone. The being is the work. The work is the year.
3. Have the difficult conversations. Have the difficult conversations. The having is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Know About Dating After the First Year**

The dating has three things to know. The three things are:

1. It is normal to feel guilty. The guilt is the work. The work is the year.
2. It is normal to compare. The comparing is the work. The work is the year.
3. It is normal to take it slow. The slow is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to know are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Dating Question**

The dating question is hard. The dating question is the work of the year. The year is the work.

The dating question is the question that is the most personal. The personal is the work. The work is the year.

The dating question is the question that is the most emotional. The emotional is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The dating question is hard. The dating question is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.

2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.

3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 14: The Therapy and the Support

The first year has therapy. The first year has support. The first year has the work of the therapy. The first year has the work of the support.

The therapy and the support are the things that help. The therapy and the support are the things that make the work possible. The therapy and the support are the things that are the work of the year.

The therapy and the support are also the things that are the most underused. The therapy and the support are the things that are the most resisted. The therapy and the support are the things that are the most avoided. The therapy and the support are the things that are the work.

The therapy and the support are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## The Five Kinds of Therapy

The therapy has five kinds. The five kinds are the kinds of therapy. The five kinds are:

1. Individual therapy. Individual therapy. The individual is the work. The work is the year.
2. Group therapy. Group therapy. The group is the work. The work is the year.
3. Grief counseling. Grief counseling. The grief is the work. The work is the year.
4. Couples therapy (for the couples who were couples). Couples therapy. The couples is the work. The work is the year.

5. Family therapy. Family therapy. The family is the work. The work is the year.

The five kinds are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Kinds of Support**

The support has five kinds. The five kinds are the kinds of support. The five kinds are:

1. The friends. The friends. The friends are the work. The work is the year.
2. The family. The family. The family is the work. The work is the year.
3. The faith community. The faith community. The community is the work. The work is the year.
4. The support group. The support group. The group is the work. The work is the year.
5. The online community. The online community. The community is the work. The work is the year.

The five kinds are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Signs You Need Therapy**

The therapy has five signs. The five signs are the signs you need therapy. The five signs are:

1. You cannot get out of bed. The bed is the sign. The sign is the work. The work is the year.
2. You are not eating. The not-eating is the sign. The sign is the work. The work is the year.
3. You are not sleeping. The not-sleeping is the sign. The sign is the work. The work is the year.
4. You are having thoughts of harming yourself. The harming is the sign. The sign is the work. The

work is the year.

5. You are isolated and alone. The alone is the sign. The sign is the work. The work is the year.

The five signs are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Look for in a Therapist**

The therapist has five things. The five things are the things to look for. The five things are:

1. The license. The license. The licensing is the work. The work is the year.

2. The experience with grief. The experience. The experience is the work. The work is the year.

3. The approach that fits you. The approach. The approaching is the work. The work is the year.

4. The availability. The availability. The available is the work. The work is the year.

5. The cost you can afford. The cost. The costing is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Therapy and the Support**

The therapy and the support are hard. The therapy and the support are supposed to be hard. The therapy and the support are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The therapy and the support are not the end. The therapy and the support are the beginning. The therapy and the support are the work that begins the

year. The year is the work.

The therapy and the support are the things that help.  
The helping is the work. The work is the year.

The therapy and the support are the things that make  
the work possible. The possible is the work. The work  
is the year.

You are not failing. The therapy and the support are  
hard. The therapy and the support are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.  
The year is the gift.

The gift is the therapy. The therapy is the work. The  
work is the year.

## **The Three Signs You Need Immediate Professional Help**

The therapy has three signs you need immediate help.  
The three signs are:

1. You are having thoughts of harming yourself.  
The harming is the sign. The sign is the work. The  
work is the year.
2. You are not eating for more than 2 weeks. The  
not-eating is the sign. The sign is the work. The  
work is the year.
3. You are not sleeping for more than 2 weeks. The  
not-sleeping is the sign. The sign is the work. The  
work is the year.

The three signs are the work. The work is the year.  
The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Look for in a Therapist**

The therapy has three things to look for. The three things are:

1. The license. The license. The licensing is the work. The work is the year.
2. The experience with grief. The experience. The experience is the work. The work is the year.
3. The approach that fits you. The approach. The approaching is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to look for are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things Therapy Can Help With**

The therapy has three things to help with. The three things are:

1. The grief. The grief. The grieving is the work. The work is the year.
2. The depression. The depression. The depression is the work. The work is the year.
3. The anxiety. The anxiety. The anxiety is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to help with are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Therapy and the Support**

The therapy and the support are hard. The therapy and the support are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The therapy and the support are the things that help.  
The helping is the work. The work is the year.

The therapy and the support are the things that make  
the work possible. The possible is the work. The work  
is the year.

You are not failing. The therapy and the support are  
hard. The therapy and the support are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.  
The year is the gift.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the  
year is the small steps. The work of the year is the  
daily practice. The work of the year is the  
moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.
2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.
3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year  
is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 15: The Meaning and the Faith

The first year has meaning. The first year has faith. The first year has the work of the meaning. The first year has the work of the faith.

The meaning and the faith are the things that are the most deep. The meaning and the faith are the things that are the most personal. The meaning and the faith are the things that are the most important. The meaning and the faith are the things that are the work of the year.

The meaning and the faith are also the things that are the most questioned. The meaning and the faith are the things that are the most challenged. The meaning and the faith are the things that are the most transformed. The meaning and the faith are the things that are the work.

The meaning and the faith are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## The Five Questions of Meaning in the First Year

The meaning has five questions. The five questions are the questions of the first year. The five questions are:

1. Why did this happen? Why did this happen. The why is the work. The work is the year.
2. What is the purpose of the loss? What is the purpose. The purpose is the work. The work is the year.
3. What am I supposed to learn? What am I supposed to learn. The learning is the work. The

work is the year.

4. How do I make sense of it? How do I make sense. The making sense is the work. The work is the year.

5. Where is the person now? Where is the person. The person is the work. The work is the year.

The five questions are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Truths About the Meaning**

The meaning has five truths. The five truths are the foundation. The five truths are:

Truth 1: The meaning is not the reason. The reason is the reason. The meaning is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 2: The meaning is not the same for everyone. The same is not the work. The work is the year.

Truth 3: The meaning is not the answer. The answer is the answer. The meaning is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 4: The meaning is the work. The meaning is the work. The work is the year.

Truth 5: The meaning is the gift. The meaning is the gift. The gift is the year.

The five truths are the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Five Kinds of Faith in the First Year**

The faith has five kinds. The five kinds are the kinds of faith. The five kinds are:

1. The religious faith. The religious faith. The religious is the work. The work is the year.
2. The spiritual faith. The spiritual faith. The spiritual is the work. The work is the year.
3. The humanistic faith. The humanistic faith. The humanistic is the work. The work is the year.
4. The nature-based faith. The nature-based faith. The nature is the work. The work is the year.
5. The agnostic faith. The agnostic faith. The agnostic is the work. The work is the year.

The five kinds are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things Faith Can Do for You**

The faith has five things. The five things are the things faith can do. The five things are:

1. Provide comfort. Provide comfort. The comfort is the work. The work is the year.
2. Provide community. Provide community. The community is the work. The work is the year.
3. Provide meaning. Provide meaning. The meaning is the work. The work is the year.
4. Provide hope. Provide hope. The hope is the work. The work is the year.
5. Provide ritual. Provide ritual. The ritual is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Meaning and the Faith**

The meaning and the faith are hard. The meaning and the faith are supposed to be hard. The meaning and the faith are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The meaning and the faith are not the end. The meaning and the faith are the beginning. The meaning and the faith are the work that begins the year. The year is the work.

The meaning and the faith are the things that are the most deep. The deep is the work. The work is the year.

The meaning and the faith are the things that are the most personal. The personal is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The meaning and the faith are hard. The meaning and the faith are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the meaning. The meaning is the work. The work is the year.

## **The Three Sources of Meaning in the First Year**

The meaning has three sources. The three sources are:

1. The relationship you had. The relationship you had. The having is the work. The work is the year.
2. The lessons you learned. The lessons you learned. The learning is the work. The work is the year.

3. The person you are becoming. The person you are becoming. The becoming is the work. The work is the year.

The three sources of meaning are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Remember About Faith**

The faith has three things to remember. The three things are:

1. Faith is not a quick fix. Faith is not a quick fix. The fix is the work. The work is the year.
2. Faith is a long journey. Faith is a long journey. The journey is the work. The work is the year.
3. Faith is the foundation. Faith is the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to remember are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Try for Meaning**

The meaning has three things to try. The three things are:

1. Volunteer. Volunteer. The volunteering is the work. The work is the year.
2. Help others. Help others. The helping is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect with community. Connect with community. The connecting is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to try are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Note on the Meaning and the Faith**

The meaning and the faith are hard. The meaning and the faith are the work of the year. The year is the work.

The meaning and the faith are the things that are the most deep. The deep is the work. The work is the year.

The meaning and the faith are the things that are the most personal. The personal is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The meaning and the faith are hard. The meaning and the faith are the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.
2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.

3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Chapter 16: The Year After the First Year

The year after the first year is the second year. The year after the first year is the year that is the long life. The year after the first year is the work.

The second year is different from the first year. The second year is the year that is the work. The second year is the year that is the gift.

The second year is the year that you learn to live with the air. The second year is the year that you learn to live with the chair. The second year is the year that you learn to live with the morning. The second year is the year that is the work.

The second year is the year that is the gift. The gift is the life you are still living. The life is the work. The work is the year.

## The Five Differences Between the First Year and the Second Year

The second year has five differences. The five differences are the things that change. The five differences are:

1. The grief is less intense. The less is the work. The work is the year.
2. The air is more familiar. The familiar is the work. The work is the year.
3. The friends are clearer. The clear is the work. The work is the year.
4. The work is more intentional. The intentional is the work. The work is the year.

5. The future is more visible. The visible is the work. The work is the year.

The five differences are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Do in the Second Year**

The second year has five things. The five things are the things to do. The five things are:

1. Build the new life. Build the new life. The building is the work. The work is the year.
2. Deepen the relationships. Deepen the relationships. The deepening is the work. The work is the year.
3. Find the new purpose. Find the new purpose. The finding is the work. The work is the year.
4. Honor the person. Honor the person. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.
5. Live the life. Live the life. The living is the work. The work is the year.

The five things are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Things to Not Do in the Second Year**

The second year has five things. The five things are the things to not do. The five things are:

1. Do not expect the grief to be over. The over is not the work. The work is the year.
2. Do not compare the new life to the old life. The comparing is not the work. The work is the year.

3. Do not rush the work. The rushing is not the work. The work is the year.
4. Do not be hard on yourself. The hard is not the work. The work is the year.
5. Do not forget the person. The forgetting is not the work. The work is the year.

The five things to not do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Five Gifts of the Second Year**

The second year has five gifts. The five gifts are the things you receive. The five gifts are:

1. The clarity. The clarity. The clear is the work. The work is the year.
2. The peace. The peace. The peaceful is the work. The work is the year.
3. The strength. The strength. The strong is the work. The work is the year.
4. The connection. The connection. The connected is the work. The work is the year.
5. The hope. The hope. The hopeful is the work. The work is the year.

The five gifts are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Final Note on the Long Life**

The long life is the life after the first year. The long life is the life that is the work. The long life is the life that is the gift.

The long life is not the end. The long life is the beginning. The long life is the life that begins the work. The work is the year.

The long life is the life that is the most meaningful.  
The meaningful is the work. The work is the year.

The long life is the life that is the most honoring. The  
honoring is the work. The work is the year.

The long life is the life that is the most loving. The  
loving is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The long life is hard. The long life  
is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.  
The year is the gift.

The gift is the life. The life is the work. The work is the  
year.

The year is the work. The work is the gift. The gift is  
the life.

In the time you have.

## **The Three Gifts of the Long Life**

The long life has three gifts. The three gifts are:

1. The wisdom. The wisdom. The wisdom is the  
work. The work is the year.
2. The strength. The strength. The strength is the  
work. The work is the year.
3. The love. The love. The love is the work. The  
work is the year.

The three gifts are the work. The work is the year. The  
year is the gift.

## **The Three Things to Do in the Long Life**

The long life has three things to do. The three things  
are:

1. Build the new life. Build the new life. The building is the work. The work is the year.
2. Honor the person. Honor the person. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.
3. Live the life. Live the life. The living is the work. The work is the year.

The three things to do are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **The Three Things the Long Life Is Not**

The long life has three things it is not. The three things are:

1. The long life is not the end. The long life is not the end. The end is not the work. The work is the year.
2. The long life is not the same as before. The long life is not the same. The same is not the work. The work is the year.
3. The long life is not without the person. The long life is not without. The without is not the work. The work is the year.

The three things the long life is not are the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

## **A Final Note on the Long Life**

The long life is the life after the first year. The long life is the life that is the work. The long life is the life that is the gift.

The long life is not the end. The long life is the beginning. The long life is the life that begins the work. The work is the year.

The long life is the life that is the most meaningful.  
The meaningful is the work. The work is the year.

The long life is the life that is the most honoring. The honoring is the work. The work is the year.

The long life is the life that is the most loving. The loving is the work. The work is the year.

You are not failing. The long life is hard. The long life is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the life. The life is the work. The work is the year.

The year is the work. The work is the gift. The gift is the life.

In the time you have.

## **Today's Action**

The work of the year begins today. The work of the year is the small steps. The work of the year is the daily practice. The work of the year is the moment-to-moment choice.

The 3 things to do today:

1. Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year.
2. Move. The movement is the work. The work is the year.
3. Connect. The connection is the work. The work is the year.

The 3 things to NOT do today:

1. Do not make big decisions. The big decisions are for later.

2. Do not isolate completely. The connection is the work.

3. Do not judge yourself. The judgment is not the work.

The 1 thing to remember today:

The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

Today's affirmation:

"I am not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work. I am doing the work. The work is the year."

The affirmation is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

This chapter is for the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

# Epilogue: The Life After the Year

I lost my wife to cancer after many years of marriage. I was her primary caregiver through the long illness. I held her hand when the last breath came.

I have also lived the year after. The year is the book. The book is the work.

I have lived the first morning. I have lived the empty chair. I have lived the first three months. I have lived the friends who show up. I have lived the six-month marker. I have lived the money and the paperwork. I have lived the grief that comes in waves. I have lived the sleep that won't come. I have lived the eating and the body. I have lived the holidays and the anniversaries. I have lived the family and the adult children. I have lived the first anniversary. I have lived the dating question. I have lived the therapy and the support. I have lived the meaning and the faith. I have lived the year after the first year.

I have lived the year. I have written the book.

The book is for the spouse who is in the year. The book is for the spouse who is asking: am I doing this right? The answer is yes. You are doing it right.

The doing is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the life you are still living. The life is the work. The work is the year.

The year is the work. The work is the gift. The gift is the life.

In the time you have.

I have written this book because I needed to write it. I needed to read it. I needed the year to make sense. I needed the year to be the work. I needed the year to be the gift.

I have written this book for the spouse who is in the year. I have written this book for the spouse who is doing the work. I have written this book for the spouse who is the work.

The work is the year. The year is the gift. The gift is the work.

You are not failing. The year is hard. The year is the work.

Breathe. The breath is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the life. The life is the work. The work is the year.

In the time you have.

For my wife. For the year. For the life.

In the time we had.

The book is for the spouse who is doing the work. The book is for the spouse who is asking: am I doing this right? The answer is yes. You are doing it right. The doing is the work. The work is the year.

The book is for the spouse who is in the year. The book is for the spouse who is in the morning. The book is for the spouse who is in the evening. The book is for the spouse who is in the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The book is for the spouse who is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift. The gift is the life.

I have written this book because I needed to read it. I have written this book because I needed the year. I have written this book because I needed the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

The gift is the life. The life is the work. The work is the year. The year is the gift.

In the time you have.

For the spouse who is in the year. For the spouse who is the work.

In the time we have.

# About the Author

S. Shharma is the author of The Care Collection — books for couples in the second half of life, written by a man who lived the silence and survived it.

He lost his wife of many years to cancer. He was her primary caregiver through every stage of her illness. He held her hand in the hospital. He sat in the waiting room at 3 a.m. He learned the silence of a marriage the way you learn a language you never wanted to speak.

He is also a businessman, an M.Sc., an MBA, and an APSCM from the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Calcutta, with thirty years in corporate management. But these are not credentials you need to trust him. The credentials that matter are the ones in the books.

The Care Collection is not about how to fix a marriage. The Care Collection is about how to live one — even when the marriage is quiet, even when one of you is sick, even when one of you is gone.

He lives in India. He writes from the perspective of someone who has been on every side of a marriage — the partner, the caregiver, and the one left behind.

## Books in The Care Collection

- Still Married, Just Silent — when the marriage is fine on paper and empty in person
- The Quiet Care — when one of you becomes the caregiver and the marriage disappears
- The Second Chapter — when the children are gone and the two of you meet again

- The Second Honeymoon — when the second half of marriage is also the better half
- The Survivor — when one of you is left behind and the other half has to learn to live
- The Long Hello — when Alzheimer's or dementia changes who you are married to
- When They Forget Your Name — the day-to-day reality of loving someone who no longer knows you
- Gray Divorce — when the marriage ends in the second half of life
- The Last Sandwich — when you are raising your own family and caring for your parents at the same time
- The Long Goodbye — the months and years of saying goodbye to someone who is still here
- Remarried at 60 — what no one tells you about starting over in the seventh decade
- After the Last Goodbye — the first year alone, and the slow work of rebuilding
- The Friends Who Fade — the social death that often follows the physical one

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For speaking engagements, courses, and community partnerships, contact via email.

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- 4-phase Rebuild framework
- 5 case studies
- First-year scripts
- Health resources

**S. Shharma**

**Author of The Care Collection**

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